



UNITED: Manmohan and Sonia

SIPRA DAS

Trying to Solve Riddles

DELHI Congressmen are still trying to solve some of the riddles that came up during the AICC session. It was easy to guess who party President Sonia Gandhi was referring to when she asked them not to make their criticism against government policies public. But many

were perplexed when HRD Minister Arjun Singh pleaded that those with less merit than others and those not as well educated as some others, should not be ignored. "I am reaching the end of my life so I can take the risk of offending some people," he added. This left party

leaders, including Rahul Gandhi, puzzled about the target. More so as this comment came soon after the young Gandhi had stressed the need for meritocracy. Few, however, missed Tourism Minister Ambika Soni, J&K Chief Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad and Parliamentary Affairs Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi, not known to

be best of friends, sitting next to each other. Dasmunshi tried to explain it as the sitting together of all former Youth Congress chiefs. But his colleagues wanted to know if this was in response to Sonia's comments against infighting.

Interestingly, it was at Dasmunshi's instance that the political resolution condemned Nandigram. Initially External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee argued against it, claiming coalition compulsions, and Nandigram was clubbed with the Naxal menace. But both Dasmunshi and General Secretary Mohsina Kidwai argued for a stand-alone mention. Also interesting to note was the fact that political adviser to Congress president Ahmad Patel chose not to sit on the dais with party officials but was instead seen scribbling notes to his colleagues sitting on the stage. **by Priya Sahgal**

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Some secretaries close to the establishment are said to be primarily responsible for the move to raise the retirement age of babus from 60 to 62. Their sole aim: to block eligible but inconvenient officers from aiming for the top job.

VOICES



"Neither Rahul nor I have a magic wand. What has to happen has to happen with your (party members') cooperation."

Sonia Gandhi, Congress president

"Corruption, in Meghalaya, is a borrowed culture. This culture does not belong to us."

P.A. Sangma, former Lok Sabha Speaker

"We were never against upper castes. I wanted reservation for upper castes and minorities. Without them, our dream of social engineering cannot become a reality."

Mayawati, BSP chief and Uttar Pradesh chief minister

"During the 15 years of RJD rule, there was jungle raj in Bihar. Now there is maha jungle raj. The Nitish Kumar Government has failed on all fronts. Now give LJP a chance."

Ram Vilas Paswan, Lok Janshakti Party president

"Blame it on my face, which gives you the impression that I'm under pressure. Inside I'm cool and relaxed. I know I'm leading Pakistan and I can't afford to lose my composure."

Shoaib Malik, Pakistan cricket captain

